Women Mean Business



Running a business profitably should be compelling proof of performance. Yet, for many women executives, even a healthy bottom line is not enough to command the authority their results should earn them. Whether they have climbed the corporate ladder or stepped into a family business, women often find that securing recognition as leaders is a battle.

This is the key theme of this year's Most Powerful Women in Business issue. As in the previous year, we relied on profit after tax (PAT) as the basis of our annual ranking. This year, we refined the methodology further to focus on sustained performance. *Prince Tyagi* of *BT* Research examined around 5,500 listed companies and shortlisted those with consolidated net profit of at least ₹100 crore in FY26. This exercise yielded 130 women-led companies. Of these, the top 100 were ranked on weighted measures of average profit, profit growth, consistency of profitability, and operating profit margin over FY24-26.

The recognition, however, extends beyond listed companies. We continue to acknowledge women leading unlisted enterprises, start-ups, and global firms through our Super Achievers category.

The data reveals the performance. The top 100 women-led companies in this year's ranking reported a combined profit of ₹2.11 lakh crore, an increase of 6% over the previous year. From ₹1.32 lakh crore in FY22, combined profits rose 59.4% to ₹2.11 lakh crore in FY26, an annualised growth rate of 12.4%.

But the numbers tell only part of the story. The paths women business executives take to the top are varied, as are the challenges they have to surmount.

In our cover story, *Priyanka Sangani* examines the changing role of women in family businesses. More women from promoter families are stepping into leadership, helped by higher education and more open succession practices. But while the family name may grant a corner office early on, credibility and broader acceptance are earned over time and with effort. Preserving the legacy of earlier generations and embarking on a new growth journey, while taking experienced managers along, remain key priorities.

For professional executives, the challenges are different. As *Krishna Gopalan* reports, women are moving into senior roles across manufacturing, mining, technology, and retail, besides financial services. Economic growth and technological change have created new opportunities, and many executives have a proven track record of tackling demanding assignments. Yet sometimes staying the course is difficult for many professionals, particularly during the middle years of their careers. Companies that offer flexibility can retain experienced women professionals and maintain a robust leadership deck.

The rankings show what India's businesswomen have delivered in terms of financial performance. The stories go beyond the numbers to explore what it took them to lead.

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